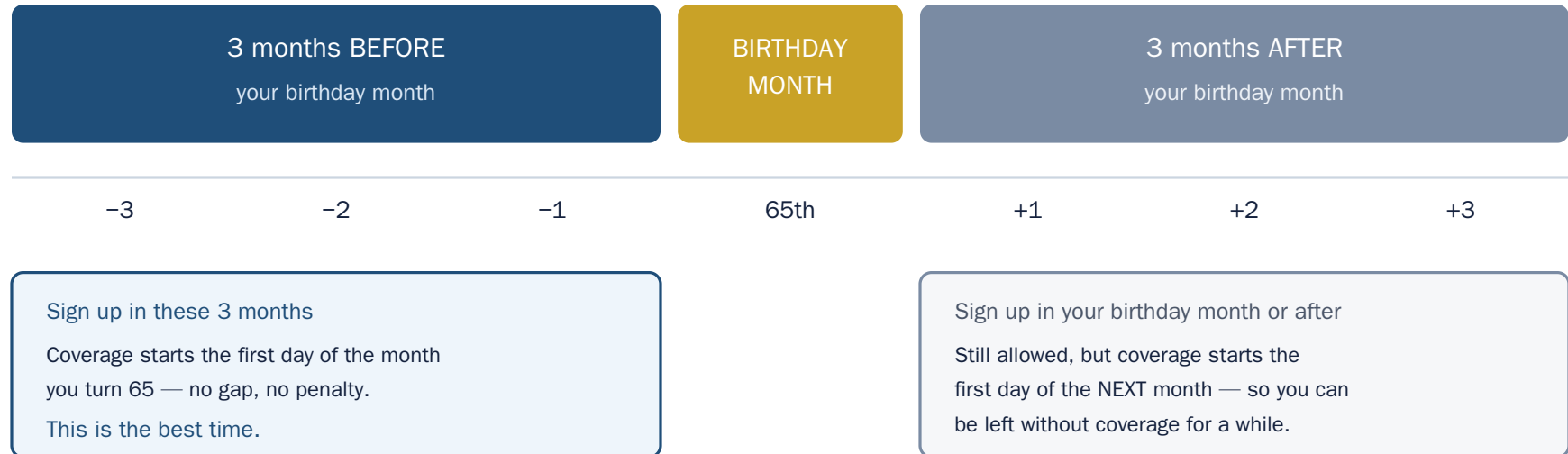


Your Medicare sign-up window is 7 months long

It opens 3 months before the month you turn 65 — and when you sign up changes when coverage starts.



Miss all 7 months and you may pay a late-enrollment penalty for as long as you have Medicare.

Different rules apply if you are still working and covered by a large employer's plan.

[mediprimer.org](https://www.mediprimer.org)

The parts of Medicare, and what each one pays for

Original Medicare is Part A and Part B. Part D is added for drugs. Part C is a different way to get it all.

PART A — Hospital

Inpatient hospital stays. Skilled nursing after a hospital stay. Hospice care. Some home health care.

PART B — Medical

Doctor visits. Outpatient care. Preventive screenings. Lab tests. Durable medical equipment.

PART D — Drugs

Prescription drugs you pick up at a pharmacy. Sold by private plans. Each plan covers its own list of drugs.

PART C — Medicare Advantage

A private plan that replaces Original Medicare. It must cover everything Parts A and B cover, usually includes Part D, and often adds extras. In exchange you use the plan's network of doctors and follow its approval rules.

Medicare does not pay for long-term custodial care, and Original Medicare has no yearly limit on what you pay.

[mediprimer.org](https://www.medicprimer.org)

Medicare, Medicaid, or both?

They are different programs with different rules — and having both is common.

MEDICARE

Based on age or disability

You are 65 or older, or you have had disability benefits for 24 months, or you have ESRD or ALS. Your income does not matter.

MEDICAID

Based on income

Your income and assets are under your state's limits. Rules and names differ by state. Any age.

BOTH — DUAL ELIGIBLE

You qualify for each

Medicare pays first, Medicaid fills gaps. Premiums, copays and long-term care may be covered. Most help available.

If you have Medicare and a low income, check Medicaid and the Medicare Savings Programs. Many people who qualify never apply.

[mediprimer.org](https://www.mediprimer.org)

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The Medicare year: which window is open when

These windows repeat every year. Outside them, you usually cannot change your coverage.

Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
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Open Enrollment — Oct 15 to Dec 15
Join, switch or drop a plan for next year

Medicare Advantage Open Enrollment

One change if you are already in an Advantage plan

General Enrollment — Jan 1 to Mar 31

For people who missed their first chance to sign up

A life event such as moving, losing other coverage, or qualifying for Extra Help can open a Special Enrollment Period at any time of year.

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What Medicare Costs in 2026

One page with the numbers people actually ask about. Print it, keep it on the fridge, or send it to a parent. Every figure comes from medicare.gov and is dated, so you can tell at a glance whether it is current.

Print this card

What Medicare Costs in 2026

The standard amounts. Your costs can differ if your income is higher, if you have a Medicare Advantage or Medigap plan, or if you get help paying.

Part A — Hospital

Monthly premium \$0 for most people

If you have to buy Part A \$311 or \$565 a month if you have to buy it

Hospital deductible \$1,736 per benefit period

Hospital days 61–90 \$434 a day

Lifetime reserve days \$868 a day

Skilled nursing facility \$217 a day (days 21–100)

Part B — Doctors and outpatient care

Monthly premium \$202.90 a month (more if your income is higher)

Yearly deductible \$283 a year

Your share after the deductible Usually 20% of the approved amount

Open enrollment ends December 7. We'll remind you.

Get our fall review checklist — the short list of things to check on your plan before the deadline — plus one reminder email before December 7. Nothing else, no ads, no plan sales.

Your email address

A reminder before the deadline, then our usual one-email-a-week-at-most. Unsubscribe in one click.

Part D — Prescription drugs

Most you pay out of pocket \$2,100 a year, then you pay nothing more for covered drugs

Highest deductible a plan may charge No plan may charge more than \$615

National base premium \$38.99 a month (used to figure late penalties)

Figures for 2026 from medicare.gov. If your income is limited, programs may pay these for you — see [mediprimer.org/getting-help.html](https://www.medicaprimer.org/getting-help.html). Free help: 1-800-MEDICARE or your SHIP counselor.

[mediprimer.org](https://www.medicaprimer.org)

The Basics

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- [Case Managers & Navigators](#)

Directories & Tools

- [State Medicaid](#)
- [SHIP \(Medicare help\)](#)

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- [All Resources](#)
- [Printable Checklists](#)

Official sources

- [Medicare.gov](#)
- [Medicaid.gov](#)
- [CMS.gov](#)
- [HealthCare.gov](#)

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For Members & Caregivers

Printable Checklists

Practical step-by-step guides for Medicare enrollment, annual reviews, appeals, caregiving, and getting help. Print or save as PDF.

Print these checklists

Tip: use your browser's print function and choose "Save as PDF" to keep a copy.

For the fall review specifically, the fillable [Annual Review Workbook](#) takes you through it step by step.

Turning 65 / New to Medicare

You have limited time when you turn 65 or start Medicare through disability or ESRD. This checklist helps you meet key deadlines.

- Note your Initial Enrollment Period (IEP) dates and deadlines.
- Decide between Original Medicare (Parts A and B) or Medicare Advantage (Part C).
- Consider whether you need Part D (prescription drug coverage) or want to enroll later.
- If switching from employer coverage, understand your Special Enrollment Period.
- Compare Medigap plans if you choose Original Medicare — once you're 65 or older and have Part B, you get a 6-month window with guaranteed acceptance. (Under 65 on Medicare? Medigap rights depend on your state.)
- Check whether your current doctors and medications are covered under your chosen plan.
- Set up your free Medicare.gov account to track enrollment, view your benefits, and access resources.

[Learn more about turning 65 and enrollment deadlines](#)

Annual Review (Every Fall)

The Annual Enrollment Period runs October 15 to December 7. Review your plan even if you want to keep it.

- Request or download your plan's Annual Notice of Change (ANOC) — sent to you in the fall.
- Check for changes: premiums, deductibles, copays, and out-of-pocket maximums.
- Check your medications against the new drug formulary.
- Verify your doctors are still in your plan's network for next year.
- Use Medicare's Plan Finder tool to compare available plans in your area.
- Switch plans by December 7, or stay put with your current plan.

[Learn more about enrollment periods and deadlines](#)

Open enrollment ends December 7. We'll remind you.

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Your email address

A reminder before the deadline, then our usual one-email-a-week-at-most. Unsubscribe in one click.

Before You Appeal a Denial

If your claim is denied, you can appeal. Here's how to prepare and meet your deadline.

- Find your denial notice — it includes your appeal deadline and instructions.
- Find your appeal level: redetermination, reconsideration, hearing, or higher.
- Gather supporting records: invoices, medical records, explanation of benefits (EOB), doctor's statement.
- Ask your doctor for a letter of medical necessity if it helps your case.
- Note the deadline for filing your appeal and the method (mail, phone, online).
- Keep copies of everything you submit.
- If you're unable to appeal yourself, consider help from a SHIP advisor or legal aid in your state.

[Get step-by-step guidance on how to appeal](#) · [Understand your appeal rights](#) · [See appeal deadlines and procedures](#)

Caregiver Document Kit

Caregivers managing someone's healthcare need key documents organized and easy to find. Collect and keep these together.

- Insurance cards (Medicare, Medicaid, supplemental insurance, prescription drug plan) — front and back.
- Plan name, member ID number, and group number.
- List of current doctors: names, phone numbers, specialties, and office addresses.
- List of current medications (names, dosages, frequency) and pharmacy contact info.
- Copy of any durable power of attorney (POA) or authorized-representative paperwork.
- Key online login information (or secure password manager access) for mail, benefits, and health portals.
- Upcoming appeal deadlines and claims waiting for decisions.
- Emergency contact numbers and after-hours plan support lines.

[Learn more about supporting a loved one](#)

Applying for Medicaid / Help Paying

If your income is low, you may qualify for Medicaid, Medicare Savings Programs, Extra Help, or other aid. Gather your documents before you apply.

- Gather income proof: last 2 months of pay stubs, tax return, or Social Security statement.
- Gather household info: number of people in your household, their income, and relationship to you.
- Keep current contact information: address, phone, and email.
- Check your state's income limits for Medicaid eligibility.
- Apply through your state's Medicaid agency — find your state on [medicaid.gov](https://www.medicaid.gov) or apply through [Healthcare.gov](https://www.healthcare.gov).
- Ask about Medicare Savings Programs — they help pay premiums and out-of-pocket costs.
- If eligible for Part D coverage, apply for Extra Help to lower your prescription drug costs.
- Follow up: keep your contact information current so the agency can reach you with updates.

[Learn what help is available for people with low income](#) · [Find your state Medicaid office](#)

Verify at the source: These checklists are educational guides. Always verify current deadlines, eligibility rules, and specific details through official plan documents, your state agency, [Medicare.gov](https://www.medicare.gov), or [Medicaid.gov](https://www.medicaid.gov). Rules and deadlines change, and what applies depends on your personal situation, state, and plan.

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